

Strategy Decision Record

You are not only choosing a direction. You are building the reasons it will be judged by.

1 • Name what is pulling against what

Which two legitimate objectives cannot both be met? If you cannot name a second one, this is probably a business case rather than a strategic choice.

2 • Say why it is hard here

What makes this difficult in this organisation that would not be difficult elsewhere? Why has the obvious answer not already been taken, and who would have to lose for it to be?

3 • Choose, and rule something out

Direction becomes real at the point of exclusion. What will not be pursued? Name who loses by it. If nothing costs anybody anything, nothing has been decided.

4 • Check you are allowed to

Necessity is settled inside the organisation. Permission is settled outside it. Name who grants it, and ask whether they would recognise your account of what you are doing.

5 • Set both clocks

How long can this be expected to hold, and what would reopen it? And by when must it be decided, set by whatever is moving against you rather than by the diary.

The record

THE DECISION, IN ONE SENTENCE

THE INTENT: THE CONDITION WE ARE TRYING TO CREATE

THE TENSION, AND WHAT KIND IT IS

WHAT WE ARE RULING OUT, AND WHO LOSES BY IT

THE STRATEGIC HOW: THE MECHANISM, NOT THE PROJECT

WHAT BEARS ON IT (MARK EACH SETTLED OR UNSETTLED)

CONFIDENCE, DURABILITY, AND THE DECISION HORIZON

RECOMMENDS / DECIDES / ACCEPTS / PERMITS / IMPLEMENTS / REVIEWS

REVIEW TRIGGER